

Organizational Change Management

Overview

GitLab is growing fast and we have been ranked as one of the fastest-growing private software companies. Headcount has nearly doubled in the last year and we have plans to continue to grow. As we scale, there will be more and more changes to how we operate as an organization. New technology will be introduced to make us more efficient, new processes will be introduced to improve transparency, functional groups will be redesigned and adjusted to meet our growing headcount and strategic objectives, job families will change, and policies in the handbook will be altered that have a big impact on how we operate.

We have created a comprehensive Change Management framework to help GitLab team members navigate change effectively, whether organizational transitions, leadership shifts, cultural evolution, implementing new technology, or any change we encounter. Our goal is to provide a clear philosophy, structured framework, and practical resources to ensure changes are implemented successfully while maintaining our culture of transparency, iteration, and collaboration.

Purpose

GitLab is in a period of evolution. During times like these, having a consistent approach to change management becomes critical. This framework ensures that whether you're leading change, supporting it, or experiencing it, everyone understands our philosophy and approach.

We seek to build change resilience across the organization, where every team member feels equipped to adapt and thrive through transitions.

What is Change Management at GitLab

Change Management at GitLab is a structured, iterative approach to guiding teams through transitions with purpose, people, and data at the center. Our framework ensures changes are aligned with strategy, executed effectively, and embedded sustainably while reinforcing our remote, transparent, and handbook-first culture.

Core Principles:

- Purpose-Driven: Every change starts with a clear "why"
- People-Centered: Success depends on human experience and engagement
- Data-Informed: Decisions are based on metrics and feedback
- Iterative: Changes evolve through continuous improvement
- Transparent: Open communication throughout the process

When to Use Our Change Management Framework

At GitLab, there are many use cases for applying our change management framework. Consider it a methodology to apply when rolling out major initiatives that impact our people and ways of working.

Examples of when to use change management include:

- Organizational restructuring or leadership changes
- Cultural transformation initiatives
- Adoption of new technology that all team members will use (e.g., new systems, tools, or platforms)

- Implementing new processes (e.g., succession planning, performance management updates)
- Rolling out organization-wide programs (e.g., 360 reviews for all team members)
- Updating total rewards policies (e.g., benefits plan iterations)
- Changing significant policies that impact daily work
- Implementing new systems or tools that may be seen as contentious
- Strategic initiative rollouts
- Significant team restructures

Examples of when the full change management framework may not be necessary:

- Announcing new GitLab product features
- Communicating executive-level updates that come directly from leadership
- Implementing iterative changes that have a track record of team member input
- Standard handbook updates and communications
- Providing awareness for company-wide initiatives (e.g., Family and Friends Day)
- Training team members on new skills or technical capabilities

Not every change project at GitLab requires the full methodology to be applied. Consider applying change management when there are major people, process, technology, and policy changes that impact team members' ways of working.

Why Change Management is Important

Organizational change is necessary for GitLab to succeed and grow. Change management drives the successful adoption and usage of change within the business. It allows team members to understand and commit to the shift and work effectively during it.

What's In It For Me (WIIFM):

- For Everyone: Clear communication about what's changing and why
- For Leaders: Tools and frameworks to guide teams through transitions effectively
- For Managers: Practical resources to support team members and maintain productivity during change
- For Team Members: Understanding of how changes affect daily work and how to adapt successfully

Everyone Plays a Role in Change

Successful change management requires participation from everyone. While roles and responsibilities may differ, everyone contributes to successful transitions:

E-Group Leadership drives change by setting vision and strategic direction, removing organizational barriers, and championing change publicly. They experience change through communications, cross-functional dependencies, and balancing speed with stability.

Director + translate strategy into tactics, coach managers through change, and allocate resources effectively. They manage multiple competing initiatives, budget constraints, and pressure from multiple directions.

Managers focus on day-to-day implementation, maintaining team morale, and providing ground-truth feedback. They balance business-as-usual work with change initiatives while addressing team member concerns and resistance.

Team Members adapt new ways of working, provide honest feedback, and support peers through transitions. They experience changes to daily workflows, learn new tools and processes.

GitLab's 8-Phase Change Management Framework

Our comprehensive framework guides teams through change with eight distinct phases, each building on the previous to ensure sustainable adoption and success.

| Phase | Core Purpose | Objective | Sample Key Actions |

|-----|-----|-----|-----|

| 01/Align | Clarify vision, spark urgency | Establish purpose & why, urgency, and sponsorship | • Identify the why behind the change
• Craft problem/opportunity statement with clear business rationale
• Secure executive sponsor and clarify their specific role |

| 02/Analyze | Surface reality informed with data | Uncover current-state facts, risks, and readiness | • Collect quantitative metrics on current performance
• Conduct readiness assessment to gauge team receptiveness
• Map impacts across systems, processes, and roles |

| 03/Plan | Map destination milestones and metrics | Define future state, success metrics, and roadmap | • Create detailed description of the future state with specific behaviors
• Set OKRs/KPIs that will indicate successful change adoption
• Outline phased milestones with clear deliverables |

| 04/Prepare | Equip teams, remove barriers | Equip teams and remove implementation barriers | • Develop role-specific training and enablement materials
• Identify and train change champions across teams
• Establish support channels (Slack, office hours, etc.) |

| 05/Communicate | Tell the story, invite dialogue | Broadcast narrative, invite dialogue, maintain transparency | • Implement BRIDGE communication framework
• Conduct AMA (Ask Me Anything) sessions at key milestones
• Create targeted messages for different stakeholder groups |

| 06/Activate | Launch change, secure early wins | Execute rollout, capture quick wins | • Implement pilot program or phased release
• Conduct regular stand-ups to address emerging issues
• Recognize and celebrate early adoption and successes |

| 07/Monitor | Track signals, measure momentum | Track metrics and sentiment to sustain momentum | • Review performance dashboards on regular cadence
• Conduct pulse surveys to gauge adoption and sentiment
• Report progress to stakeholders transparently |

| 08/Adapt | Embed change, continue to iterate | Integrate improvements permanently and continue to iterate | • Update handbook and standard operating procedures
• Integrate change metrics into regular business reviews
• Create feedback loops for ongoing refinement |

Key Framework Notes

Leadership Engagement: Visible leadership is key to success on any large-scale transformation at GitLab. Team members look to leaders for cues on how to interpret change and what actions to take. Leadership drives team member engagement and adoption of change.

Data-Driven Approach: The ultimate purpose of change management is to get team members to adopt the change and implement it in their day-to-day roles. Focus on user adoption and measure it regularly so we can adjust the communications and training approach.

Continuous Feedback: Part of successful change management is creating a positive experience and sentiment for team members around large organizational changes. This means team members feel their feedback was heard, and they understand the positive impact of the change.

BRIDGE Communication Framework

The BRIDGE Framework is our structured approach to communicating change effectively. It ensures that all change communications acknowledge concerns, provide clarity, and encourage dialogue.

The Five Elements of BRIDGE:

B - Big Picture: Start by framing the change within the larger organizational context. Explain the "why" behind the decision, connecting it to company growth, market conditions, or strategic priorities. This helps people see beyond their immediate concerns to understand the broader rationale.

R - Recognize the Reality: Acknowledge the current situation honestly and transparently. Validate concerns and emotions without minimizing them. Show that you understand this change may feel uncertain or challenging. Being authentic about the reality builds trust and credibility.

I - Identify what's Intact: Highlight the elements that remain stable - core values, strategic priorities, team objectives, or job security. This provides psychological safety by showing that not everything is in flux. People need anchors during change to feel grounded.

D - Define what's Different: Clearly articulate what will change, when it will happen, and how it affects different groups. Be specific about new processes, structures, or expectations. Clarity reduces anxiety and helps people prepare for the transition.

G - Give the Go-Forward: Provide clear next steps, timelines, and expectations. Explain how the team will navigate the change together. Focus on actionable items and how success will be measured. This shifts the conversation from "what's happening to us" to "what we're doing next."

E - Encourage and Engage: Create space for questions, concerns, and input. Show confidence in the team's ability to succeed while remaining open to feedback. Make it clear that dialogue is welcome and that you're committed to supporting them through the transition.

A Manager's Role in Change Management

Managers play a crucial role in change management success. They serve as the bridge between strategic vision and daily implementation, focusing on making business transitions successful by determining discrete steps and their sequence.

Managers can be concentrated on implementing change effectively by:

- **Translating Strategy:** Breaking down high-level changes into actionable steps for their teams
- **Maintaining Morale:** Supporting team members through uncertainty and resistance
- **Providing Feedback:** Offering ground-truth insights from their teams to leadership
- **Coaching Through Change:** Helping individual team members adapt and succeed
- **Balancing Priorities:** Managing business-as-usual work alongside change initiatives

By learning how to preempt and address challenges associated with change, managers ensure they are equipped with the skills and knowledge needed to manage transitions effectively.

Getting Started with Change Management

To prepare for GitLab transformations and changes:

1. **Assess Your Situation:** What phase are you in? How much time do you have? Who are your key stakeholders? What's your biggest risk?

2. Create Your Essentials: Draft your From→To→Because statement, list top 5 stakeholders, identify executive sponsor, choose communication channels

3. Build Your Support: Meet with sponsor, identify change champions, schedule stakeholder conversations, create feedback mechanisms

4. Apply the Framework: Use our 8-phase approach, implement BRIDGE communications, and iterate based on feedback

Change management doesn't stop once you've successfully executed the transition. Throughout and following the process, continuously assess outcomes, measure data, support team members with new methodologies and practices, and readjust goals as necessary to increase adoption.

Please contact the Learning & Development team if you would like more of an understanding of OCM and how to apply the methodology to a change/transformation at GitLab!

Additional Resources on Organizational Change Management

- Change Management Primer (Slides) (Video)
- Change Management Toolkit
- BRIDGE Framework
- Change Template
- Change Management FAQ
- Understanding Resistance to Change

Contact Us:

- Slack: #learninganddevelopment